

Practice responding to the oral defense questions.

Choose at least three questions from the sample questions provided, preferably one from each section, and respond to the questions you choose. Remember to use specific examples from your research.

Sample Oral Defense Questions:

Research/Inquiry Process [choices made throughout the research process]

1. How did your initial exploration of the scholarly conversation lead to your final research question/project goal?
2. How did your review of the methods used by scholars in the field inform your selection of a research method/process that is aligned with your research question/project goal?
3. How did the choices you made when designing or implementing your research method impact your research process?
4. How did you determine which results generated by your research method were most important in informing your new understanding?

Depth of Understanding [relating student data/results to the new understanding]

1. How does your new understanding address a gap in the scholarly conversation?
2. How did the limitations of your method or data influence your new understanding?
3. What are the real-world implications or consequences related to your findings?
4. How do your findings provide directions for future research in the field?

Reflection Throughout the Inquiry Process [how the inquiry process informs growth and self-awareness as a researcher]

1. Think back to the initial curiosity that sparked your inquiry. What other curiosities do you have and how has this process prepared you to explore them?
 2. How did you handle the uncertainty of the research process?
 3. If you could revisit your research process, what would you do differently and why?
 4. What was the most important research skill you developed as a result of this process, and
 5. how might you apply it to your future endeavors?
 6. How did your expert adviser facilitate your deeper understanding of the research process?
- Note: This question should only be asked if the student engaged with an expert adviser.

Response 1

How did your review of the methods used by scholars in the field inform your selection of a research method/process that is aligned with your research question/project goal?

As I reviewed the literature on how people react to algorithms, scholars like Cotter and Eslami et al. used qualitative methods. However, my research question explored how algorithms impact the creative identity of small visual artists. To study this phenomenon, I used Braun and Clarke's (2006) framework for qualitative discourse analysis. This approach allowed me to analyze nine

texts to compare how small visual artists and platforms describe key concepts using their chosen language. This technique best suited my investigation into the emotional impacts of algorithms on small visual artists.

Response 2

How does your new understanding address a gap in the scholarly conversation?

Researchers such as Duffy and Abidin have studied visibility labor within the context of influencers and YouTubers. However, small independent visual artists have mostly been ignored in this context. Through my research on defensive creativity, I found that small visual artists often describe the algorithm as an economic gatekeeper to their creative selfhood. In response to this threat to their creative identities, they employ defensive creativity to protect their authenticity in a world of algorithmic constraints. Their actions include moving their following to newsletters or their personal websites. This finding adds a crucial dimension to the existing literature on the topic.

Response 3

If you could revisit your research process, what would you do differently and why?

If I were to perform this study again, I would include interviews with small visual artists. Analyzing the six artist blog posts and articles showed important insights into the challenges they face from social media algorithms. In my discussion of limitations, I acknowledged that these blog posts and articles are not direct interviews with the artists. The artists wrote these pieces to convey their perspective and offer advice to other visual artists. Conducting interviews could have allowed me to ask follow-up questions and to learn more about the feelings that these artists have concerning their creative trap. This would have given me a closer look at their changing creative identities.

It may be helpful to practice these responses out loud in front of a mirror or a peer or family member.